

The Fridge Map

Five foods the cold quietly ruins — where they really belong, and how long each lasts when you get it right.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. Refrigeration feels safe, but for some foods the cold is exactly what spoils them — breaking down starches, drawing in moisture, and killing flavor. Move these five off the cold shelf and you will throw away less, taste more, and stretch every grocery run further.

KEEP OUT OF THE COLD

- **Potatoes** — cold converts their starch into sugar, leaving them gritty and oddly sweet, and darkening them when cooked. Keep in a paper bag somewhere cool and dark.
Pantry: 2-3 weeks. Cool cellar (45-50F): several months.
 - **Onions** — fridge humidity turns them soft and moldy and steals their crispness. Store dry, dark, and airy, never sealed in plastic. Lasts about 1-2 months.
 - **Garlic** — the moisture of the fridge makes heads sprout and mold. Keep whole, skin on, in an open bowl out of sunlight. Lasts 3-6 months.
 - **Tomatoes** — cold makes them mealy and dull and stops the flavor developing. Keep on the counter, stem-side down, out of direct sun. Only refrigerate a dead-ripe tomato, and only to buy a day or two.
 - **Bread** — surprisingly, the fridge stales bread faster than the counter. Keep at room temperature in a bag for 2-4 days, or freeze it for up to 3 months and toast from frozen.
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THESE ACTUALLY KEEP LONGER COLD

- **Cut or peeled fruit and vegetables** — once the skin is broken, cold slows spoilage and bacteria.
 - **Berries and leafy greens** — refrigerate dry and unwashed; rinse only just before eating, since moisture invites mold.
 - **Dairy, eggs, and any cooked leftovers** — always cold, and within two hours of cooking.
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KEEP THIS IN MIND

Never store onions and potatoes side by side. Each gives off gases and moisture that make the other sprout and rot faster. Keep them in separate corners and both last far longer.

Small knowledge, kept and used, is what a well-run home is built on. Save this map to your fridge door, and watch how little you throw away. — The Sage

SOURCES USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service (fsis.usda.gov) · Utah State University Extension, Storing Fruits & Vegetables · Michigan State University Extension · University of Florida IFAS Extension (FS260)

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